Walhalla falls to top-ranked BHP

By Caleb James

For The Journal

WALHALLA — Facing one of the top teams in South Carolina, The Walhalla High School football team couldn't overcome a lightning-fast start from Belton-Honea Path on Friday night, falling 62–7 in their regular-season finale at home.

The Bears struck on their very first play when quarterback Noah Thomas connected with receiver Tajeh Watson-Martin for a 51-yard touchdown. Then, after recovering an onside kick, BHP scored on the first play of its next possession to take a 14–0 lead less than two minutes into the game. That explosive start set the tone for the night as the Bears showed why they're among the state's most dominant programs.

"We were shell-shocked that first quarter," said Walhalla head coach Blake Dyar. "They hit us with a deep pass, an onside kick, and another quick score before we could settle in. Our guys' heads were spinning."

By the end of the opening quarter, BHP led 28–0. Thomas threw for four touchdowns overall, and Watson-Martin had a career night with three scoring catches and a 55-yard punt return touchdown. The Razorbacks, however, found their footing in the second quarter and began to move the ball effectively.

Quarterback Caleb Johnson led a promising drive midway through the period, finding Caden McCall on a 36-yard strike to put Walhalla on the board. The touchdown was one of the bright spots in an otherwise challenging night for the Razorbacks, who showed flashes of promise despite facing a powerhouse opponent.

"After that first quarter, it was 7–7 in the second," Dyar said. "We moved the ball well before a fumble set us back, but I was proud of our fight."

Walhalla's defense tightened up briefly before halftime, forcing a few stops and limiting the Bears to shorter gains. Still, BHP took a 35–7 lead into the half and never looked back. The Bears added 27 more points in the second half. Running back MJ Earl led the way for BHP with 116 yards and two touchdowns on just five carries. The Bears finished with 477 total yards, including 225 rushing, while Walhalla managed 136 yards of offense.

Despite the lopsided final score, Dyar emphasized the progress his young roster has made in recent weeks. Several freshmen and underclassmen saw extended action, a development he believes will pay off in the future.

"We had about four freshmen in by midway through the second quarter," Dyar said. "They're going to be here for a long time and they're going to see some wins in the future."

The loss dropped Walhalla to 2–8 overall, but they will enter the playoffs looking to build on their improved execution and effort from the later stages of the game. Dyar said the focus this week will be on carrying over that resilience and cleaning up early mistakes.

“We’re not going to play anybody else that good unless we see them again in the playoffs,” Dyar said. “We’ve consistently gotten better week after week. The scoreboard doesn’t show it, but we played hard tonight.”

Even in defeat, the Razorbacks left the field encouraged by their response after a difficult start, and confident that the lessons learned Friday can help them make the most of their postseason opportunity.

Walhalla 7, Belton Honea Path 62

WHS 0 7 0 0 — 7

BHP 28 7 13 14 — 62

SCORING SUMMARY

First Quarter

BHP — Watson-Martin 51 pass from Thomas (Ward kick), 10:11

BHP — Earl 45 run (Ward kick), 9:57

BHP — Watson-Martin 58 pass from Thomas (Ward kick), 6:47

BHP — Watson-Martin 55 punt return (Ward kick), 4:30

Second Quarter

BHP — Glenn 37 pass from Thomas (Ward kick), 7:11

WHS — McCall 36 pass from Johnson (Cobb kick), 3:08

Third Quarter

BHP — Glenn 12 pass from Thomas (Ward kick), 7:59

BHP — Ware 3 run (kick failed), 1:13

Fourth Quarter

BHP — Earl 4 run (Ward kick), 7:49

BHP — Tate 38 pass from Foster (Ward kick), 2:57

TEAM STATISTICS

WHS BHP

First Downs 10 24

Total Yards 136 477

Rushes-Yards 16-19 20-225

Fumbles-Lost 2-2 0-0

Com-Att-Int 8-18-1 8-14-0

Passing Yards 117 252

Pen-Yards 5-35 14-130

Punts-Avg. 4-43.5 0-0

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INDIVIDUAL STATISTICS

RUSHING — Walhalla, Certain 7-18, Leslie 2-7, Johnson 4- -1, Nathan 3- -5 Belton Honea Path, Earl 5-116, Hester 5-50, Ware 3-12, Robinson 2-14, Miles 1-11, Gaines 1-10, Paul 1-13, Turner 1-9, Thomas 1-3.

PASSING — Walhalla, Johnson 7-17-1 117, Miles 0-1-0 0; Belton Honea Path, Thomas 7-13-1 214, Bohler 1-1-0 38.

RECEIVING — Walhalla, McCall 3-59, Nathan 5-29, Butler 3-16, Donald 1-6, Cobb 1-7; Belton Honea Path, Watson-Martin 3-118, Glenn 5-79, Gaines 1-17, Tate 1-38.